MA ENGLISH • SEMESTER 1

Block 2 — Unit 4: Drama - The Tempest and Antony and Cleopatra

SHAKESPEARE STUDIES • M21EG02DC

Expanded exam notes | Simple teaching + developed argument

Based on the supplied SGOU self-learning material. Use the assigned primary texts for exact quotations and full scene or passage analysis.

The chapter in one sentence

The Tempest explores control and reconciliation, while Antony and Cleopatra examines love and political identity across rival imperial worlds.

Start with a picture

One powerful person directs events from an island; another struggles to belong simultaneously to Rome and Egypt. Both plays ask how rule depends on performance, loyalty, and the ability to tell a convincing story about oneself.

1. The Tempest: who is on the island?

Prospero, the displaced Duke of Milan, lives with Miranda. His brother Antonio helped overthrow him. Ariel is a spirit bound to Prospero’s service; Caliban claims the island through his mother Sycorax. Alonso, Ferdinand, Sebastian, Gonzalo, and others arrive through Prospero’s staged storm.

Follow the action

The storm separates the visitors. Miranda and Ferdinand fall in love, while Prospero tests and manages their courtship. Antonio and Sebastian plot against Alonso. Caliban joins Stephano and Trinculo in another rebellion. Ariel’s work frustrates conspiracies and supports Prospero’s spectacle. Prospero eventually moves towards forgiveness, discloses identities, gives up his magic, and prepares to return to Milan.

Ariel and Caliban: compare, do not flatten

Ariel repeatedly seeks promised freedom. Caliban challenges dispossession and imposed service. Both are under Prospero’s authority, but their histories, languages, and modes of resistance differ. Neither should be explained only through Prospero’s account.

Power, art, and colonial reading

Prospero’s magic resembles theatrical direction. He controls movement, visibility, and experience. A postcolonial reading asks about possession, labour, naming, and representation. This is a critical framework, not proof that the island maps exactly onto one modern colony.

Forgiveness must also be tested: who offers it, who must accept it, and whose account remains marginal?

2. Antony and Cleopatra: central figures

Antony is a Roman leader attached to Cleopatra, ruler of Egypt. Octavius Caesar competes for Roman power. Enobarbus, Antony's associate, provides a crucial perspective. Octavia's marriage to Antony is part of political negotiation.

Follow the main movement

Antony moves between Roman obligations and his relationship with Cleopatra. Political accommodation proves unstable. War brings defeat, including the battle of Actium. Antony misreads news and suffers a failed suicide attempt before dying with Cleopatra. Cleopatra resists being displayed as Caesar's captive and chooses death. Caesar survives to organise the political account of what has happened.

Rome and Egypt are contested images

Roman speeches may associate Rome with duty and Egypt with excess. The play also reveals Roman manipulation and Egyptian political calculation. Do not simply adopt a character's stereotype as Shakespeare's final judgement.

Cleopatra's complexity

She is a ruler, lover, negotiator, performer, and maker of her final image. Her changes of tone are part of her dramatic power. An answer should neither idealise her entirely nor reduce her to a temptation that ruins a man.

3. Genre and staging

The Tempest is often read as a romance: danger and separation move towards recognition. Antony and Cleopatra combines tragic loss with historical and political scale. Rapid scene changes and contrasting locations help create its divided world.

Quick check

1. Do Ariel and Caliban ask for exactly the same thing in the same way? **No; their relations to service and freedom differ.**
2. Does Prospero's story exhaust the island's history? **No.**
3. Is Cleopatra only a private lover? **No; her political and theatrical roles are central.**

Build an exam answer

1. Define performance as the management of appearances.
2. Discuss Prospero's direction and Ariel's labour.
3. Bring in Caliban's competing account.
4. Analyse Cleopatra's public and final self-presentation.
5. Compare the political implications of the endings.

Common mistake to avoid

Do not treat Rome/Egypt or Prospero/Caliban as fixed moral binaries. Use a postcolonial interpretation as an argument supported by the play, not an unquestionable map.

Developed exam discussion

Practice question

Compare the relationship between power and performance in the two plays.

Explain the argument in fuller paragraphs

In The Tempest, Prospero’s power becomes visible through his ability to arrange what others experience. The storm, separation of the visitors, controlled encounters, and masque depend on his direction and Ariel’s labour. The analogy with theatre is therefore more than decorative: rule operates by managing perception. Yet the servants’ claims and the island’s contested history make that authority ethically unstable.

Ariel and Caliban reveal different limits to Prospero’s perspective. Ariel seeks release from a promised term of service, while Caliban associates the new order with dispossession. Their contrasting forms of resistance make a simple opposition between civilised ruler and unruly subject inadequate. A reading of reconciliation must consequently ask whether Prospero’s return to political authority also settles the injustices experienced by those whose work supported him.

Antony and Cleopatra makes political identity equally theatrical, though on a different scale. Antony is measured against Roman models of leadership even while his Egyptian life unsettles those expectations. Cleopatra repeatedly acts before audiences within the play. Her final presentation challenges the image Caesar hopes to display in triumph, making self-representation a last form of resistance within military defeat.

The plays’ endings should not be made identical. The Tempest offers recognition and a prospective return, while Antony and Cleopatra creates an irreversible loss within the consolidation of Caesar’s power. Both nevertheless show that authority includes control over stories, appearances, and the judgement of spectators. A critical answer should connect this shared concern to distinct scenes and outcomes.

How to use this discussion

Adapt the argument to the exact wording and marks of your question. Use one point per paragraph and support it with a scene, line, image, or formal detail. Verify exact quotations in the assigned text. The discussion is explanatory paraphrase, not a quotation or a guaranteed model answer.

Textbook assignment checklist

These are the unit’s assignment prompts for revision. They are not predictions or a set of fully written assignment submissions.

1. Examine the postcolonial aspects in The Tempest.
2. Write a detailed comparison between the characterisation of Ariel and Caliban.

3. Is Prospero justified in his quest for revenge? Provide examples from the play to validate your answer.
4. How does William Shakespeare use romantic and historical elements to weave a tragic tale in Antony and Cleopatra?
5. Closely examine the characterisation of Cleopatra in Shakespeare’s play Antony and Cleopatra.